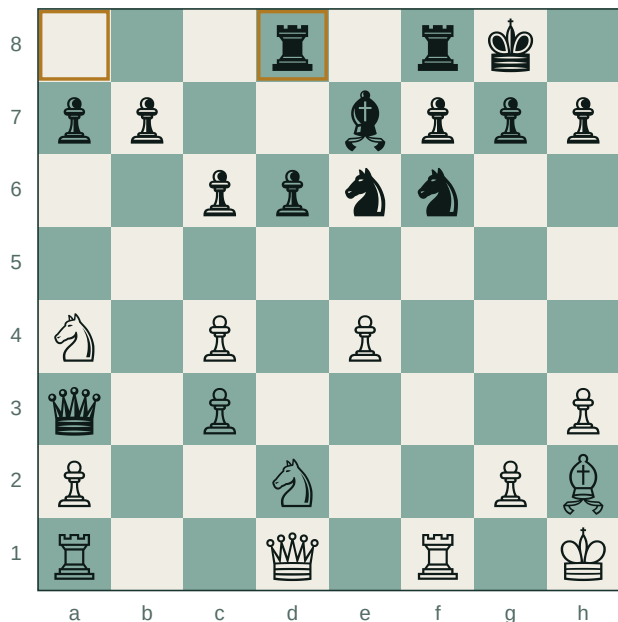


Trapping a piece: White, move 17

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 16...Rad8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17. Nb1 Qxa4 18. Qxa4

17.Nb1 The knight moves from d2 to b1. Recorded reply: **17...Qxa4**.

18.Qxa4 The queen captures the queen on a4.

At the end, nominal material is White 31 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +6. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +6: the balance goes from -1 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on e7 and queen on a3. Check for tactical protection.